

Environmental Governance in China

Independent Study

Spring 2026

Bowdoin College

1 General Information

Instructor: Weizheng Lai

Contact: By email w.lai@bowdoin.edu

Office: Hubbard 8

Office Hours: TuTh 10:30–11:30 AM & Tu 4:30–5:30 PM

Meeting Time: TBD, every other week

2 Grading

The final grade is based on two parts.

Engagement (40%): This assesses your learning efforts through our meetings and other forms of communications.

Final Report (60%): You are need to submit a report that summarizes what you have learned over the semester and possibly proposes some directions for your future learning regarding environmental governance in China. Your report may address:

- What are the major environmental issues in China?
- How do these issues impact the economy and people?
- How do the Chinese government and society react to these issues? Are the reactions effective? What are the limitations?
- What questions do you think will be important for future research on environmental governance in China?

The report should be 10–15 pages in length, double-spaced, using Times New Roman 12-point font and 1-inch margins. References, figures, and tables do not count toward the page limit. **The report is due on 5/16.**

Letter grades are assigned as follows.

Score Percentage	Grade	Notes
[90, 100)	A	
[87, 90)	A-	
[82, 87)	B+	
[78, 82)	B	
[75, 79)	B-	
[?, 75)	C- to C+	I will give some version of a C even for scores that dip into the 60 percent range.
[?, ?)	D	A score below 60 percent is likely to earn a D.
[?, ?)	F	An F will only be given in rare circumstances, such as failing multiple assignments or demonstrating no effort in the course.

3 Course Policies

Academic honesty. The relevant Honor Code clauses for this class include: “‘Academic Dishonesty’ includes but is not limited to (1) the receiving, giving, or using of any unauthorized assistance on quizzes, tests, written assignments, examinations or laboratory assignments; . . . (4) acquisition, without permission, of tests, computer files or similar material which would give the student an unfair advantage on an assignment or examination; (5) submission of academic work not a student’s own original effort.” More information can be found at: <https://www.bowdoin.edu/dean-of-students/student-handbook/the-academic-honor-code-and-social-code.html>.

Use of AI. You may use AI programs, e.g., ChatGPT, to help learn statistical software, generate ideas, and brainstorm. However, you should note that the material generated by these programs may be inaccurate, incomplete, or otherwise problematic. Beware that use may also stifle your own independent thinking and creativity. You may not submit any work generated by an AI program as your own. If you include material generated by an AI program, it should be cited like any other reference material (with due consideration for the quality of the reference, which may be poor). Any plagiarism or other form of cheating will be dealt with severely under Bowdoin’s academic integrity policies. You are responsible for assessing the quality, completeness, and accuracy of the cited information.

Late submission, extension, and makeup policies. Assignments submitted late will lose 10% of the points per day. Extensions may be granted if you contact me in advance with compelling reasons and supporting evidence. No makeup exams will be given except in cases of illness (confirmed by a doctor’s certificate), religious observance, participation in College activities at the request of the College authorities, or compelling circumstances beyond the student’s control. If at all possible, the student must inform me (or the Economics Department) of her/his situation before the exam.

Getting your learning needs met. Bowdoin College and I are committed to ensuring access to learning opportunities for all students. Please connect with me about any learning or personal challenges that arise for you over the semester that are impacting your engagement and learning in this course. I will honor any requests to reschedule an assignment or miss class due to the observation of religious holidays.

Students seeking accommodations based on disabilities must register with the **Student Accessibility Office**. Please discuss any special needs or accommodations with me at the beginning of the semester or as soon as you become aware of your needs; I am eager to work with you to ensure that your approved accommodations are appropriately implemented. If you have questions about requesting accommodations or concerns about approved accommodations, please contact Lesley Levy (llevy@bowdoin.edu), director of student accessibility, or talk with me at any time.

The **Baldwin Center for Learning and Teaching** offers peer-to-peer resources including mentors, Q-Tutors, and Writing Assistants. If you are multilingual you may also take advantage of Lisa Flanagan to work on writing and speaking assignments and projects. Tina Chong is available as an Academic Coach to work with you on goal setting, managing time, study habits and other strategies to support academic success ([link](#)).

The **Office of the Dean of Students** is also a resource for students facing personal and academic challenges. I encourage you to reach out to the people in the dean's office for a meeting anytime.

Disclaimer. This syllabus is intended to give the student guidance in what may be covered during the semester and will be followed as closely as possible. I reserve the right to modify, supplement, and make changes as the course needs arise.

4 Suggested Readings (Subject to Change)

The readings listed below are intended to introduce you to key topics covered in the course. You are encouraged to explore further by consulting the references cited in these readings or by conducting your own literature search. If you identify an article that is of substantial interest and would like to use it as a substitute for one of the suggested readings, please email me for approval.

4.1 Some Basics in Environmental Economics

Objective: Study some economic approaches to environmental questions.

- 1/20–1/30:
 - Introduction: [slides](#) by Mark Witte @Northwestern
 - Pigouvian Approach: [slides](#) by Mark Witte @Northwestern

4.2 China's Environmental Challenges

Objective: Study major environmental issues in China, especially those related to water, air, and soil.

- 2/2–2/13:
 - [Liu and Diamond \(2005\)](#)
 - [Khan and Chang \(2018\)](#)
 - [Barwick et al. \(2024\)](#): read introduction and section 1.A
 - [Greenstone et al. \(2021\)](#)
 - [Ebenstein \(2012\)](#): read sections 1 and 2

Objective: Study the impacts of environmental issues in China.

- 2/16–2/27:
 - [Ebenstein et al. \(2015\)](#)
 - [Ebenstein et al. \(2017\)](#): read introduction
 - [Barwick et al. \(2025\)](#): read introduction; nontechnical video at [econimate](#)

4.3 Government, Citizens, and Environment

Objective: Understand the logic behind China's policymaking.

- 3/2–3/5:
 - [Wang and Yang \(2025\)](#): read introduction; non-technical video at [econimate](#)

Objective: Learn a framework to think of the interplay between government, citizens, and environment in China.

- 3/23–4/3:
 - Ding (2022) Introduction & Ch.1–Ch.3
- 4/6–4/17:
 - Ding (2022) Ch.4–Ch.5 & Conclusion

Objective: Study (i) the determinants and impacts of China's environmental regulations and (ii) the role of citizens.

- 4/20–5/6:
 - Jia (2025): read introduction
 - He et al. (2020): read introduction; non-technical summary
 - Liu et al. (2025)
 - Buntaine et al. (2024): read introduction and section 1; non-technical summary

5 Resources

- Some economists studying China's environmental issues:
 - Shanjun Li
 - Eric Zou
 - Shaoda Wang
 - Guojun He
 - Junjie Zhang
 - Xianling Long
- EPIC-China
- Undergraduate-level environmental economics courses:
 - Mark Witte @Northwestern
 - Hunt Allcott @Stanford

References

- Barwick, Panle Jia, Shanjun Li, Ligu Lin, and Eric Yongchen Zou.** 2024. "From fog to smog: The value of pollution information." *American Economic Review* 114 (5): 1338–1381.
- Barwick, Panle Jia, Shanjun Li, Deyu Rao, and Nahim Bin Zahur.** 2025. "The Health Care Cost of Air Pollution: Evidence from the World's Largest Payment Network." *Review of Economics and Statistics* 1–19.
- Buntaine, Mark T, Michael Greenstone, Guojun He, Mengdi Liu, Shaoda Wang, and Bing Zhang.** 2024. "Does the squeaky wheel get more grease? The direct and indirect effects of citizen participation on environmental governance in China." *American Economic Review* 114 (3): 815–850.
- Ding, Iza Yue.** 2022. *The performative state: Public scrutiny and environmental governance in China*. Cornell University Press.
- Ebenstein, Avraham.** 2012. "The consequences of industrialization: evidence from water pollution and digestive cancers in China." *Review of Economics and Statistics* 94 (1): 186–201.
- Ebenstein, Avraham, Maoyong Fan, Michael Greenstone, Guojun He, Peng Yin, and Maigeng Zhou.** 2015. "Growth, pollution, and life expectancy: China from 1991–2012." *American Economic Review* 105 (5): 226–231.
- Ebenstein, Avraham, Maoyong Fan, Michael Greenstone, Guojun He, and Maigeng Zhou.** 2017. "New evidence on the impact of sustained exposure to air pollution on life expectancy from China's Huai River Policy." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 114 (39): 10384–10389.
- Greenstone, Michael, Guojun He, Shanjun Li, and Eric Yongchen Zou.** 2021. "China's war on pollution: Evidence from the first 5 years." *Review of Environmental Economics and Policy* 15 (2): 281–299.
- He, Guojun, Shaoda Wang, and Bing Zhang.** 2020. "Watering down environmental regulation in China." *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 135 (4): 2135–2185.
- Jia, Ruixue.** 2025. "Pollution for promotion." *Journal of Law, Economics, and Organization* 41 (3): 866–892.
- Khan, Mehran Idris, and Yen-Chiang Chang.** 2018. "Environmental challenges and current practices in China—a thorough analysis." *Sustainability* 10 (7): 2547.
- Liu, Jianguo, and Jared Diamond.** 2005. "China's environment in a globalizing world." *Nature* 435 (7046): 1179–1186.
- Liu, Zhuang, Wenwei Peng, and Shaoda Wang.** 2025. "Courting a Blue Sky? Understanding the Constrained Judicialization of Environmental Governance in China." *Journal of Contemporary China* 34 (155): 759–780.
- Wang, Shaoda, and David Y Yang.** 2025. "Policy experimentation in China: The political economy of policy learning." *Journal of Political Economy* 133 (7): 000–000.